INCH-POUND

PP-B-2120B
AMENDMENT-2
June 11, 1993
SUPERSEDING
PP-B-2120B
AMENDMENT-1
November 14, 1991

FEDERAL SPECIFICATION

GROUND BEEF PRODUCTS, FROZEN

This amendment, which forms a part of Federal Specification PP-B-2120B, dated May 31, 1991, is approved by the U.S. Department of Agriculture for use by all Federal agencies.

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DELETE section 3.3.1 and

SUBSTITUTE the following:

"3.3.1 **Handling and storage**. Except for hot-processed or partially chilled meat, meat that is less than 28°F (-2.2°C) or higher than 50°F (10°C), will not be accepted for initial certification. Handling and storage of certified boneless meat prior to processing into the finished product shall be in accordance with one of the following methods as declared to the Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS) agent by the contractor. Unless otherwise specified, boneless meat handled by any of the following methods may be combined in any combination and processed into the finished product. Product failing to meet the following temperature requirements will be rejected and cannot be reoffered.

a. **Same-day processing**. Fresh-chilled meat processed on the same day of initial certification shall not exceed 50°F (10°C) at any time prior to grinding.

Beneficial comments, recommendations, additions, deletions, clarifications, etc., and any data which may improve this document should be sent to: Chief, Livestock and Meat Standardization Branch, Livestock and Seed Division, Agricultural Marketing Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Room 2603, South Building, P.O. Box 96456, Washington, DC 20090-6456.

FSC 8905

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b. **Fresh-chilled storage.** Fresh-chilled meat not processed on the same calendar day of initial certification may be held up to 72 hours from the time the container holding boneless meat is sealed by the AMS agent, provided the meat does not exceed 40°F (4.4°C) at the time offered for grinding. However, if the temperature of the meat at the time offered for grinding exceeds 40°F (4.4°C), but is less than 50°F (10°C), that meat may be processed on the same calendar day provided it is reexamined for condition in accordance with the stationary lot reexamination criteria in Table I of 4.3.2. The meat shall not exceed 50°F (10°C) at any time prior to grinding.

Fresh-chilled boneless meat destined for use in the finished product, but held for more than 72 hours from the time the container holding boneless meat is sealed by the AMS agent, shall be reexamined for condition in accordance with the stationary lot reexamination criteria in Table I of 4.3.2. at the time of further processing, provided the meat does not exceed 40°F (4.4°C).

c. **Same day production of certified frozen and tempered beef products.** Miscut beef steaks, miscut diced beef, and/or trimmings derived from previously certified meat which has been frozen and tempered to facilitate slicing, dicing, or trimming may be further processed into ground beef. However, this product shall be ground on the same calendar day of slicing, dicing, or trimming and shall not exceed 40°F (4.4°C) at the time offered for grinding. **(SENTENCE DELETED)**

Dry ice or liquid nitrogen may be used to maintain the above temperatures.

d. **Frozen storage.** Fresh-chilled meat not processed on the same calendar day of initial certification may be frozen and stockpiled for later use provided it is processed not more than 60 days from the initial certification date. The boneless meat shall be frozen to an internal temperature of 0°F (-17.8°C) or lower within 72 hours following the time the container holding boneless meat is sealed by an AMS agent. Boneless meat assigned to freezing shall be stored at 0°F (-17.8°C) or lower and packaged and packed in commercial containers that are adequate to maintain product excellence during freezer storage. Containers shall be labeled as "Boneless Beef for PP-B-2120". Examination for frozen temperature requirements shall be as specified in 4.7.1 72 hour frozen temperature requirement.

The meat shall be maintained frozen during storage, and the internal temperature shall not exceed 40°F (4.4°C) when further processing is resumed.

e. **Hot-processed meat.** The temperature of meat ground on the same calendar day of slaughter shall not exceed 45°F (7.2°C) after final grinding, up to and including placement into the freezer. Previously certified fresh-chilled or frozen meat may be added prior to final grinding. Dry ice or liquid nitrogen may be used to obtain the required temperature prior to final grinding.

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f. **Partially chilled meat.** Meat exceeding 50°F (10°C), but not exceeding 65°F (18.3°C), may be processed into ground beef providing that: (1) the meat is proven* to be from animals slaughtered not earlier than the previous calendar day; (2) there is no evidence of odors or darkening or discoloration of fat or lean which might be the result of oxidation, aging, dehydration, or microbial activity; and (3) the meat is ground and placed into the freezer before the end of the calendar day on which it is first offered.

* Evidence required to prove date of slaughter and the amount of product control necessary in such cases shall be determined by the local AMS agents."

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at the end of section 3.3.3 **ADD** the following:

"Except as allowed below, the temperature of all ground beef products immediately after final grinding shall not exceed 45°F (7.2°C). Frozen beef product or dry ice may be added during the grinding and/or blending process to achieve this temperature in the finished product.

Ground beef products with a temperature greater than 45°F (7.2°C), but not greater than 50°F (10°C), will be accepted provided that: (1) the temperature of the product is reduced to 45°F (7.2°C) or below after packaging, but before packing into the shipping containers, and (2) the temperature reduction occurs within 30 minutes of the time of final grinding."

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DELETE section 3.3.5 and

SUBSTITUTE the following:

"3.3.5 **Bacteriological requirements**. Ground beef will be analyzed for bacteria levels in accordance with Chapter 9, Section 9.5.1 of the Compendium of Methods for the Microbiological Examination of Foods (second edition), published by the American Public Health Association. The product sampled shall be analyzed for psychrotropic plate count levels not exceeding 100,000 bacteria per gram. Vendors will be responsible for costs of bacteriological testing, which will be conducted at an AMS Laboratory. Testing and actions to be taken when product exceeds 100,000 bacteria per gram are specified in 4.8.3 Bacteriological sampling and testing."

Pages 19 and 20

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SUBSTITUTE the following:

"4.8.3 Bacteriological sampling and testing. Sampling of product for bacteriological testing shall be conducted according to procedures detailed in MGCB Instruction 918-2 for this purpose and approved by the AMS Science Division. The level of sampling and actions which will be taken, based on the history of the individual contractor, are as follows:

a. Product monitoring (Level I). Product shall be sampled at the beginning (within the first 5 days) of any new production of product under this specification. (Any resumption of production after a cessation of two weeks or more will be considered a new start-up for product monitoring purposes.) Additional sampling shall be conducted on a skip-lot basis--at least one sample from each 40 production lots. After each sample is selected, one of the next 40 lots will be sampled. However, contractors producing product on a continuing basis shall be tested not less often than one time a month. As long as no result exceeds 100,000 psychrotropic bacteria per gram, the contractor shall continue at this level of sampling. No reserve samples will be analyzed or appeals allowed at this level of sampling. However, if psychrotropic bacterial levels exceed 100,000 per gram, the contractor shall be converted to individual lot sampling upon verification (see section 4.8.3 b) and shall receive official notification of the status change.

   If three consecutive samples are analyzed with results of less than 25,000 bacteria per gram the contractor may elect a waiver of the examination for excellent condition (section 4.3). (Upon approval of the AMS agent and the purchaser, the contractor may request to accelerate sampling for the purpose of meeting this requirement. Acceptable evidence of consistently low bacterial levels must be shown to justify acceleration of this process.) The examination for excellent condition will be reimposed upon verification (section 4.8.3 c) of subsequent sample results exceeding 25,000 bacteria per gram. Also, any significant change in operations which, in the opinion of the AMS agent, may increase the level of bacteria in the product will result in revocation of the waiver. During any period when formal examinations for excellent condition are not being conducted, the AMS agent shall reject any lots which he/she observes which contain any product in less than excellent condition, and the waiver of such examinations shall be immediately terminated.

b. Verification of results over 100,000. Upon receiving any result over 100,000 per gram, the AMS agent shall select one lot from each of the next five days' production for analysis. If no additional result exceeds 100,000 during this period, product monitoring will resume. If a second result exceeds 100,000, the purchaser shall be notified and the contractor shall be immediately converted to individual lot sampling (section 4.8.3 d).

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c. Verification of results over 25,000. If, based on previous results, the excellent condition examination has been waived and a sample exceeds 25,000 (but less than 100,000), the AMS agent shall select one lot from each of the next five days' production for analysis. If no additional sample exceeds 25,000 the condition waiver shall remain in effect. A second sample over 25,000 shall result in termination of the excellent condition waiver and continuation of product monitoring (section 4.8.3 a). A subsequent sample over 100,000 shall be verified and acted upon as prescribed in section 4.8.3 b.

d. Individual lot sampling (Level II). The contractor must develop, and provide to the AMS agent, a formal product quality control plan to bring product into compliance with the requirements. The AMS agent shall sample all production lots for bacteriological testing, and will randomly select one lot from each day's production to send to the AMS Laboratory for analysis. When five consecutive days' results of not more than 100,000 psychrotropic bacteria per gram are obtained under individual lot sampling, the contractor shall revert to product monitoring status on the following production day. As soon as the contractor qualifies to return to product monitoring, results from other samples already submitted for analysis shall be treated as if they were selected under product monitoring. A contractor who ceases or completes production under individual lot sampling, and later restarts production with a break of less than four months, will restart at this level of sampling as well. If the contractor has not qualified to return to product monitoring when results are obtained from 20 consecutive production days under individual lot sampling, the purchaser shall be notified, and the contractor will be placed under tightened processing requirements and controls on future contracts.

e. Tightened processing requirements and controls (Level III). In consultation with the contractor and other experts, the AMS agent shall designate a product quality control plan to be followed. At this stage all production lots shall be sampled and analyzed. Additional control points and requirements may be added until product is in compliance with microbiological requirements. When 15 consecutive days' production are analyzed with no result over 100,000 the contractor shall revert to individual lot sampling under contractor control. Tightened processing requirements and controls included in the product quality control plan may include (but are not limited to) (1) lower temperature requirements, (2) conducting excellent conditions examinations only on bone-in product and reducing the time allowed for processing, (3) setting a maximum length of time between slaughter and final processing, and (4) reducing the amount of small pieces or other items allowed in the product. The MGCB supervisor shall assign the number of AMS agents necessary to assure compliance with the plan.

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f. Alternatives to Level III. (1) At the time a contractor is notified that he is being placed under Level III on future contracts, he may elect to begin to sampling at the Level III rate immediately. If, before new contracts become effective, the contractor has 10 consecutive day's without a result over 100,000, he may revert to Level I. Testing may continue under this scheme even when new contracts become effective, as long as all results stay under 100,000. However, once new contracts begin any result exceeding 100,000 shall cause Level III requirements to be implemented immediately, and 15 consecutive day's results under 100,000 will be necessary to revert to Level II.

(2) If the contractor does not elect to begin Level III sampling at the time of notification (as specified above), sampling shall continue at the Level II rate until new contracts begin. Results obtained during the interim period will be used for advisory purposes only."

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Paragraph 5.1.2 b.

ADD after the second sentence:

"In lieu of the minimum bursting strength a minimum edge crush test of 44 lbs./in. may be used."

ADD at end of the fourth sentence:

"or minimum edge crush test."

MILITARY INTERESTS:

Military Coordinating Activity

Army - GL

Custodians

Army - GL
Navy - SA
Air Force - 50

Review Activities

Army - MD, QM
Navy - MC
DP - SS

CIVIL AGENCY COORDINATING ACTIVITIES:

DOJ - BOP
HHS - NIH, IHS
USDA - FV
VA - OSS

PREPARING ACTIVITY:

USDA - LS

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